SHARAD SAXENA



GETTY IMAGES



A LONG ROAD OBC Yadav stalwarts Lalu and Mulayam, 1990; the exchange of home minister Mufti Mohammed Sayeed's kidnapped daughter Rubaiya, above, for jailed militants was a weak moment for VP

alition. Till L.K. Advani's rath yatra brought the inherent contradictions to a boiling point, VP stood against it, and the BJP withdrew support.

Chandra Shekhar's brief reign, with just 64 MPs and a lifeline from the Congress, is remembered more for being the dark pit-stop where India mortgaged tonnes of gold to stave off a balance of payments crisis. When Rajiv Gandhi pulled the plug after a couple of Haryana cops were found snooping outside his house, it seemed more like a mercy killing. The two governments together lasted barely 18 months.

Those conditioned into thinking of Congress-style stability as a virtue are prone to look askance at the second Janata interregnum. They see it as a slice of low drama, a refractory piece of chaos before order was restored. They read the arrival of Mandal with those same caustic metaphors: most charitably, they read it as pure tactical play; most cynically, they found it 'divisive'. Naturally, they miss how creative that break from status quo was, how deeply democratising, how ideas of autonomy were instilled right up to the Prasar Bharati. If it seemed somehow intrinsic to the Janata species behaviour to splinter along New Delhi's radial roads, going separate ways, it's because it was indeed the opposite of centralism in India's polity. It was power flowing outward, literally. ■



ELECTION '89 • THE NEW GOVERNMENT

NATIONAL FRONT

TURBULENT TRANSITION

One of the most complex and ultimately successful operations conducted by V.P. Singh's supporters was to neutralise Devi Lal and Chandra Shekhar.

Devi Lal, V.P. Singh and Chandra Shekhar: clever manoeuvres

Turbulent Transition
INDIA TODAY, *Dec. 15, 1989*

"The one person who emerged as the master strategist responsible for blunting the daggers being hurled in V.P. Singh's direction to prevent his emergence as prime minister was none other than Arun Nehru, the latter-day Chanakya of Indian politics. V.P. Singh's major task lay not only in finding a modus vivendi with the revivified BJP... but also in battling the formidable beasts of opposition to him that lay buried within the belly of his own party."